Business Pitch
Rion Imaging

Team: 31 | **Date:** February 2026

1 Executive Summary

Rion Imaging will deploy a dedicated microsat constellation in low lunar orbit by 2045 to provide persistent, high-resolution imaging services to a predicted £1.17B annual market spanning space agencies, governments, commercial operators, and research institutions. Our fleet-based architecture delivers superior revisit rates and cost economics compared to Firefly Aerospace's Ocula service, with projected 32% ROI and full payback by 2050 on £69.5M development costs.

2 Initial Funding Strategy

2.1 Funding Sources

Our funding strategy will be broken down into two phases of ten years each, however the funding numbers reflect total funding over the next twenty years.

Table 1: Funding Source Breakdown

Source	Description & Justification	Amount	%
Government Grants	e.g., ESA GSTP, Horizon Europe	£30.80 M	35%
Private Equity	Space-focused VCs (e.g. Seraphim)	£38.50 M	50%
Strategic Partners	e.g., Co-investment from aerospace primes	£7.70 M	15%
Total Initial Funding		£77.00 M	100%

2.2 Funding Justification

Our capital strategy is modelled on successful space imaging companies like ICEYE, which progressed from a €2.4M EU Horizon 2020 grant in 2015 to over $500M in total venture funding by 2024. [1] Initially, we will focus on government grants and institutional funding from sources such as ESA's ARTES and Lunar Exploration programmes, UKSA's National Space Innovation Programme, and Horizon Europe grants to de-risk our technology while preserving equity and establishing technical credibility, hence improving subsequent fundraising terms. [2] [3] With validated technology and institutional backing, we will then approach space-dedicated VCs including Seraphim Space and Space Capital. [4] [5] Finally, we secure strategic investment from European primes such as Airbus Ventures, which has participated in 10 Series A and 8 Series B space deals, to access supply chain integration, technology licensing, and potential customer relationships. [6]

3 Market Analysis: 2045

According to several governments and market analysts, by 2045 the cislunar space economy will have grown to be a multi-billion dollar industry, combining scientific, military, and commercial operations that all rely on a plethora of services and infrastructure to support them. [7] [8] [9] The forecast below is based on the market for Lunar imaging specifically, the data is inferred from parts of the Earth imaging market and forecasts on the size of the cislunar economy in 2045.

Table 2: Target Customer Segments for Lunar Imaging

Customer Segment	Value Proposition	Market Size Est. (2045)
Space Agencies	Supervision of lunar missions	£435 M/year
National Governments	Intelligence gathering on lunar surface	£380 M/year
Research Institutions	Scientific surface data gathering	£36 M/year
Private Enterprises	Prospecting, supervision of commercial ISRU operations, business intelligence	£326 M/year
Total Addressable Market		£1.17 B/year

Our main competitor would be Firefly and their Ocula lunar imaging service. Their proposal is based on a piggybacking model, using their blue ghost missions to place a 3 satellite constellation. [10] Our competitive advantage lies in our fleet economics and dynamic monitoring. Our daily revisit rate and microsat constellation align both with market expectations and cost evolution. High revisit rates align with permanent lunar operations, while the expected 3-5x decrease in microsat launch costs will benefit our fleet model more than Firefly's. [11]

4 Cost Breakdown

Table 3: Non-Recurring Cost Summary

Category	Description	Cost (2025)
Development Costs		
System Design and Prototyping	Preliminary & detailed design phases	£12.5 M
Software Development	Flight & Ground software, Cybersecurity	£5.5 M
Space Segment		
Assembly, Integration & Testing	Structure, propulsion, avionics, payload	£16.0 M
Ground Segment		
Mission Control & Ground Network	Facilities, equipment, software	£7.0 M
Launch Costs		
Launch Vehicle & Services	Starship, Integration, range fees	£23.0 M
Other Non-Recurring		
Licensing & Insurance	Spectrum, launch license, risk, etc..	£5.5 M
Total Non-Recurring		£69.5 M

Table 4: Annual Recurring Cost Summary (Operational Phase 2045 onwards)

Category	Description	Annual Cost (2025)
Operations	Mission operations, spacecraft control	£0.8 M
Maintenance	Software updates, anomaly resolution, Network access, data processing	£0.5 M
Insurance (In-orbit)	Operational liability coverage	£0.3 M
Personnel	Operations team, management, support	£0.85 M
Constellation Regeneration	Cost of failing cubesats	£0.9 M
Total Annual Recurring		£3.7 M

5 Pricing Plan

The pricing structure was determined through financial modelling of future costs and market trends, it was decided that a subscription-based service with four tiers was most appropriate. Our services would include two types of imaging: High Resolution Optical and Infrared, with radar-based imaging planned for the future.

Table 5: Service Pricing Structure

Subscription Tier	Description	Price (2025)
No subscription	Per image pricing	£2.25 k/image
Commercial/Academic	Standard priority service, 300 image limit per year	£0.8 M/year
Enterprise	Standard priority service with 50 high priority images, unlimited images, private database	£1.6 M/year
Defense/Security	High priority service, unlimited images, private and secured database	Negotiated

6 Financial Projections & Return on Investment

Table 6: 10-Year EBITDA & Cost Projection (Operations: 2045–2055)

	’45	’46	’47	’48	’49	’50	’51	’52	’53	’54	Total
EBITDA (£M)	11	15	17	19	21	25	29	32	36	38	240
Recurring Costs (£M)	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	3.7	37
Net Cash Flow (£M)	7.6	11	13	16	18	21	25	28	32	34	210
Cumulative (£M)	7.6	19	32	47	65	86	110	140	170	210	–

Analysis of the EBITDA projections indicates a complete return on investment by 2050, achieving an ROI of 32.0% over the 10-year operational period. The current geopolitical landscape has driven significant investment in space-based defence and intelligence capabilities, accelerating strategic lunar activity, and creating sustained demand for persistent imaging services. [12] Furthermore, the Artemis program and expanding international scientific missions, combined with emerging commercial lunar operations, establish a robust and diversified customer base. [13] Financial projections are presented on a pre-tax basis due to the volatile nature of the fiscal environment. Our financial projections incorporate these market drivers while maintaining cautious assumptions when compared to Earth-based observation services, ensuring that our projections are credible and achievable.

Table 7: ROI Analysis

Metric	Description	Value
Total Investment	Non-recurring costs + initial working capital	£69.50 M
Total Revenue (10 yr)	Cumulative revenue over operational lifetime	£242.72 M
Total Costs (10 yr)	Recurring operational costs	£81.50 M
Net Profit (10 yr)	Revenue minus all costs	£91.72 M
ROI	(Net Profit / Total Investment) $\times$ 100	**32.0%**
Payback Period	Time to recover initial investment	**Year 2050**

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